

A CASE FILE ON 1,000 STARTUPS

Everyone has a story. Only some of it holds up.

We pulled the books on 1,000 small online businesses — every dollar they made, every subscriber they kept. Then we asked: which of the patterns we noticed are actually true, and which just look true?

1,000

BUSINESSES

\$334M

TOTAL REVENUE ON FILE

65

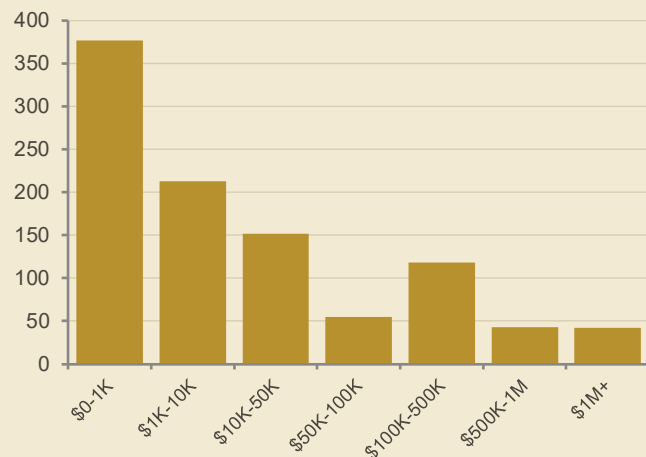
COUNTRIES

What the numbers actually show

THREE PATTERNS OBSERVED ACROSS 1,000 BUSINESSES

OBSERVED

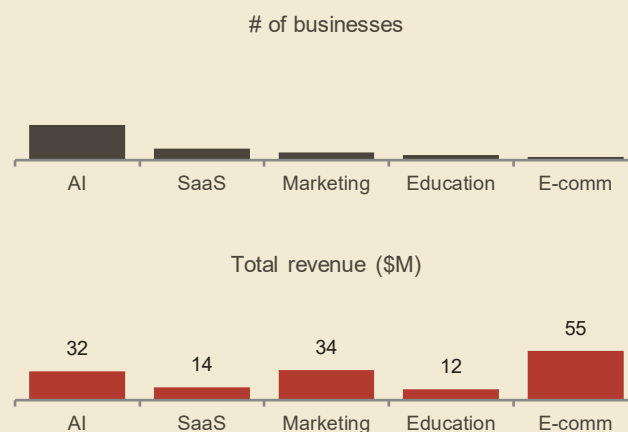
The average lies to you.



377 of 1,000 businesses have made less than \$1,000, total, ever. A handful have made millions. The “average” describes almost no one.

OBSERVED

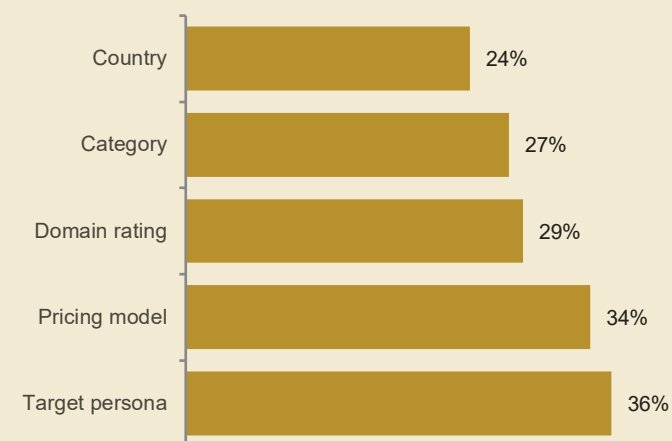
Crowded isn't profitable.



AI has 10x more businesses than E-commerce — but E-commerce brings in more total revenue. A crowded room isn't a rich one.

OBSERVED

The story is missing.



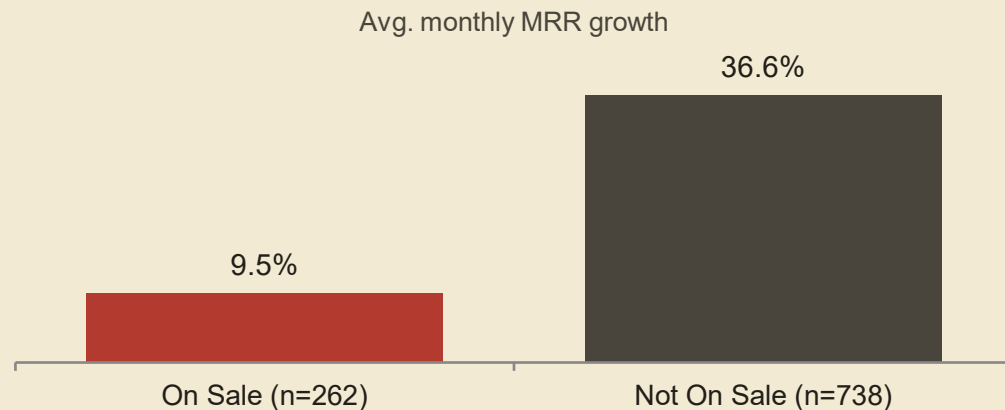
For more than a third of these businesses, we know exactly what they earned — but not who they're for.

The one thing we actually tested

CONFIRMED: NO

Is “for sale” a warning sign?

262 businesses are listed for sale. On paper, the rest look like they’re growing nearly 4x faster — so we ran a Welch’s t-test to check if that gap was real.



$p = 0.158$ — the gap is not statistically reliable. The “not for sale” group is just wildly inconsistent, not consistently better.

THE VERDICT

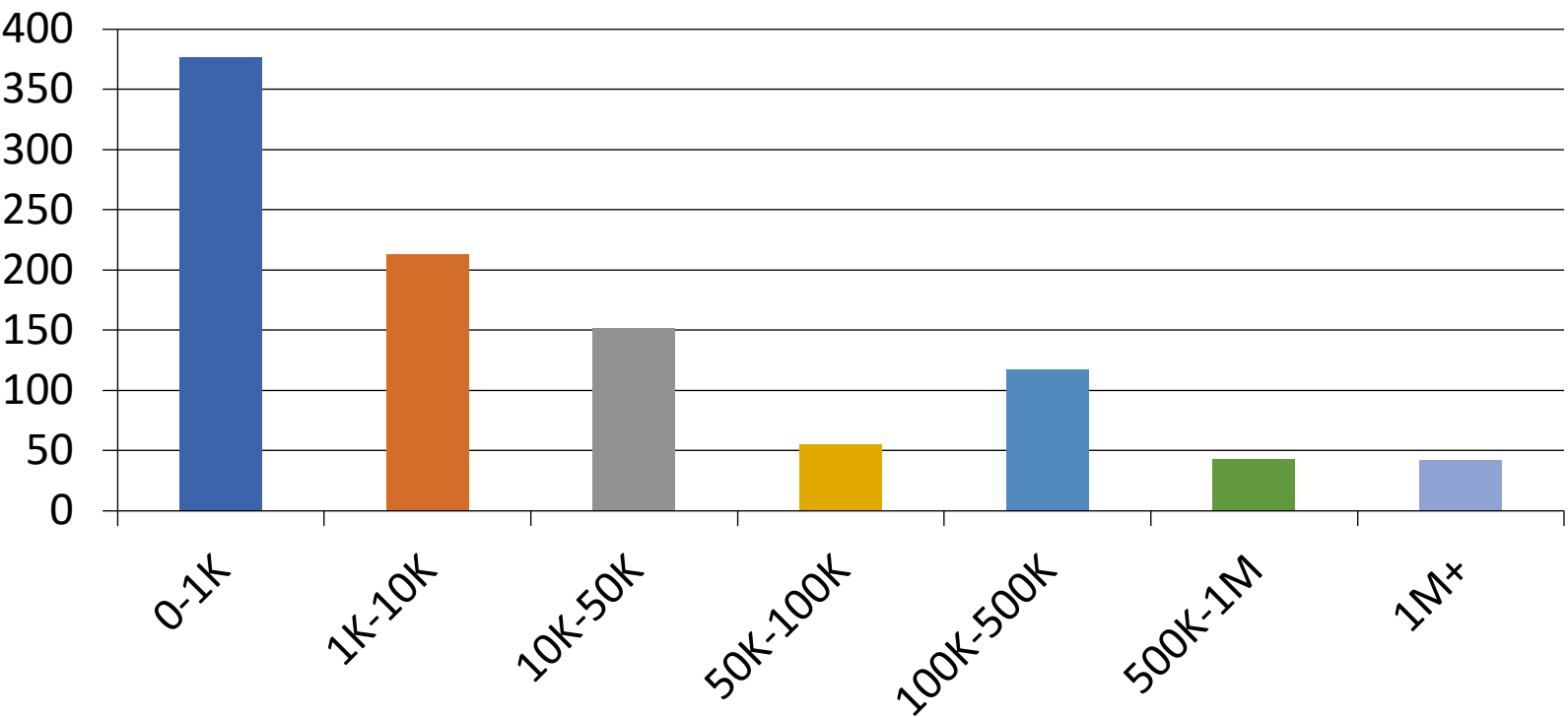
Money doesn’t follow the crowd, the category, or the follower count.

It follows a small number of businesses that are simply disproportionately good at turning attention into dollars.

CASE CLOSED

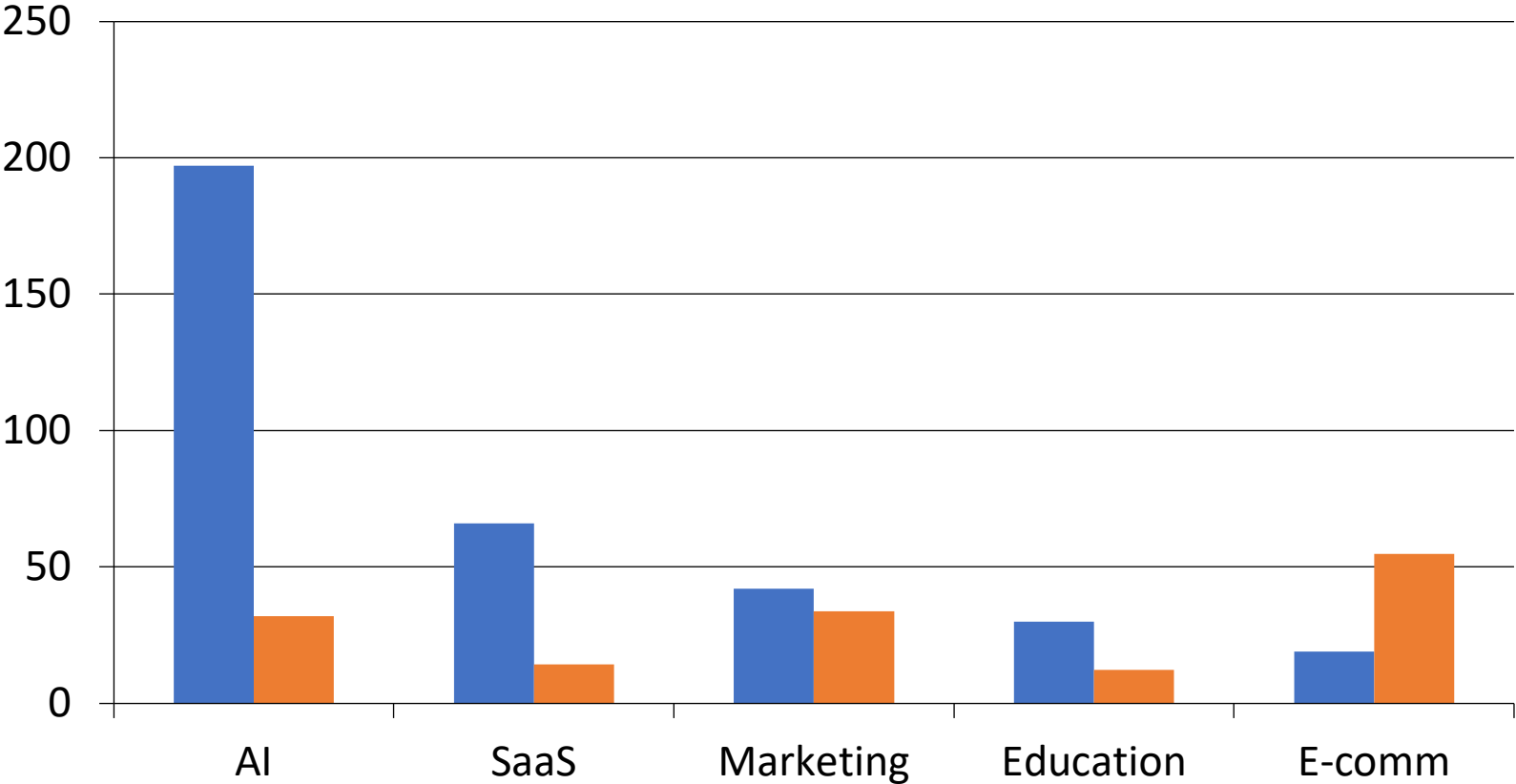
Revenue Distribution

Businesses



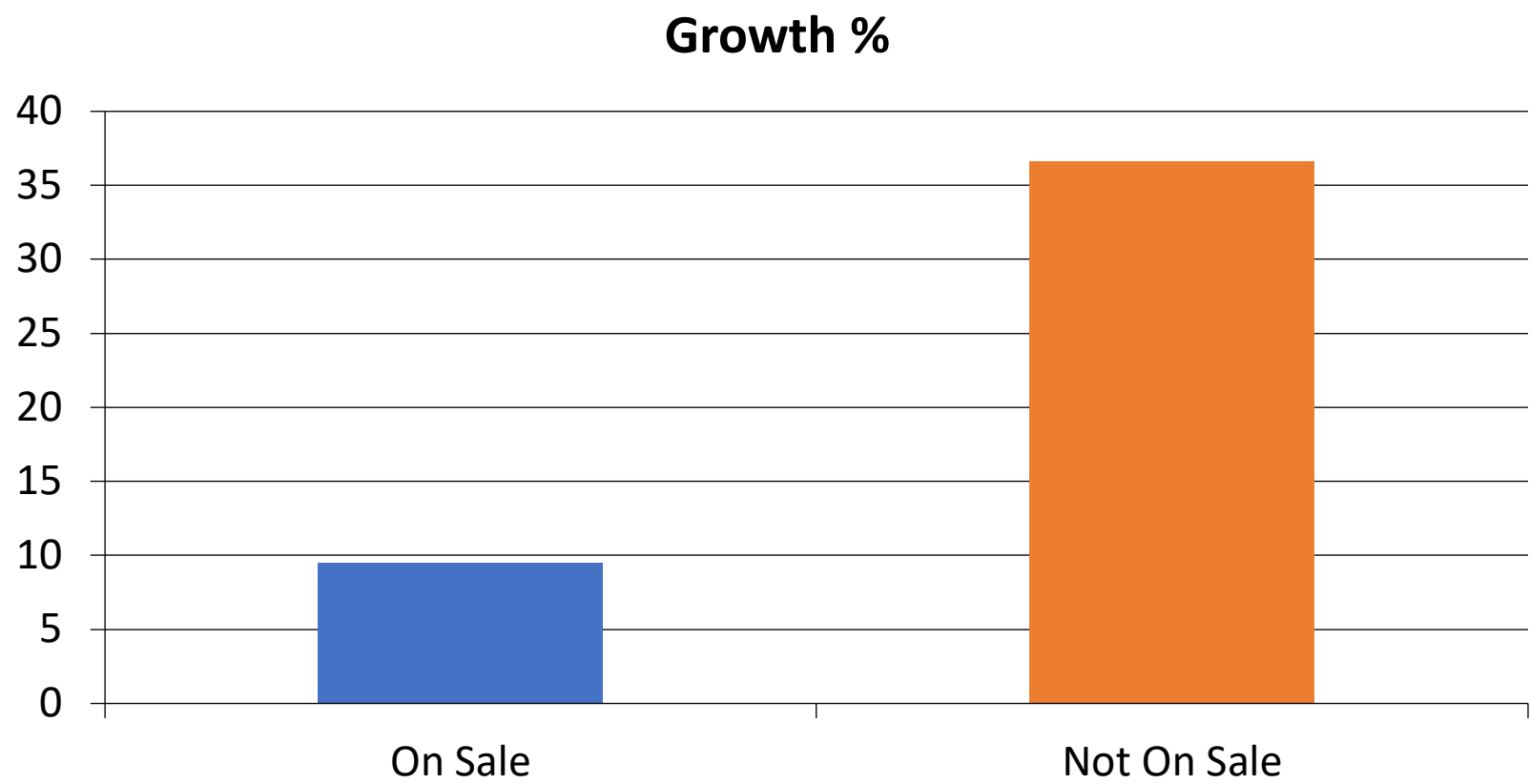
377 businesses earned < \$1K.
Average is misleading.

Category vs Revenue



AI has most startups.
E-commerce earns more.

On Sale vs Growth



p = 0.158
Not statistically significant.

Executive Conclusion

- **Success is highly concentrated** – Most startups generate very little revenue, while a small number create a disproportionate share of value.
- **Popularity ≠ Profitability** – The most crowded categories are not necessarily the ones generating the highest revenue.
- **One metric doesn't tell the whole story** – 'For Sale' status or recent revenue alone cannot reliably predict business quality.
- **Execution wins** – Businesses that consistently convert customers into recurring revenue outperform those simply following market trends.

FINAL TAKEAWAY

The biggest insight from 1,000 startups isn't who made the most money—it's that lasting success comes from execution, not trends.

Businesses that build sustainable recurring revenue consistently outperform those relying on category popularity or short-term growth.